

INTRODUCTION

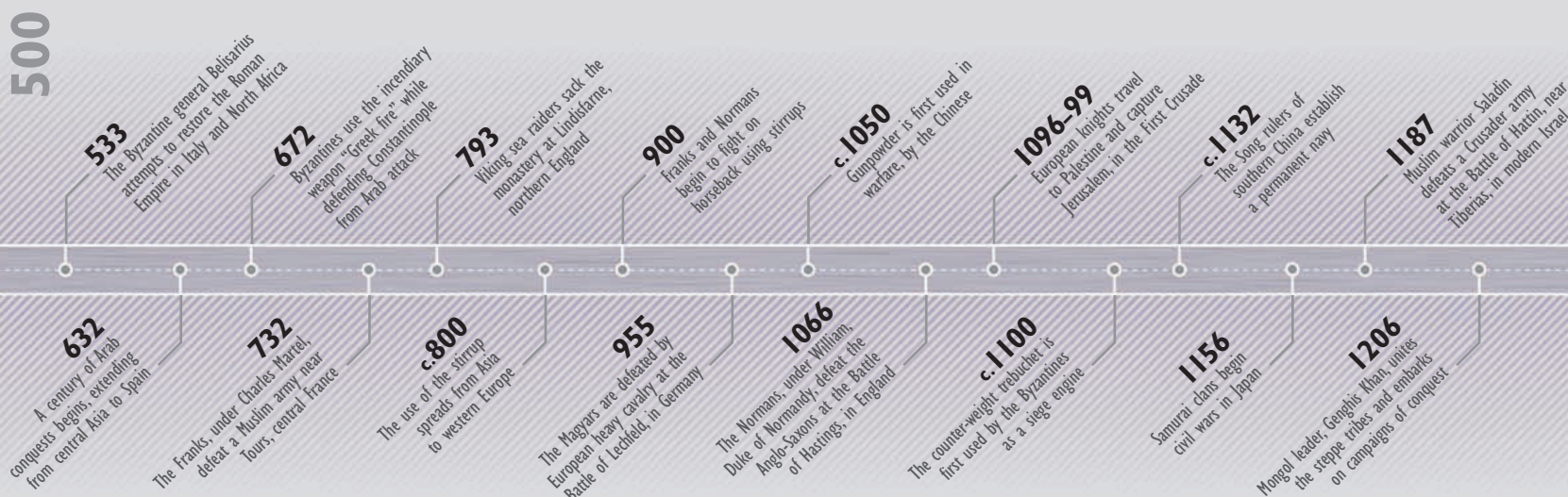
During the era known in Europe as the Middle Ages, warfare was dominated by the mounted warrior – from the armoured European knight to the steppe horseman. Military technology evolved slowly, and for a long time the bow was more influential than new gunpowder weapons.

Centres of settled civilization were often vulnerable to raids or conquest by marauding warrior tribes: despite being relatively advanced in terms of both technology and its government, China was conquered in the 1200s by the Mongols – steppe nomads using the composite bow. Religious zeal also proved as important as technological advantages: the foundation of Islam in around 600CE inspired an Arab expansionist drive, while, from around 1090, militant Christianity inspired crusades to Palestine and the retaking of Spain from Muslim rule. These insecure times saw the building of castles and other fortifications, which then became the object of attack by siege engines.

During this period, developments in metallurgy improved the quality of the steel used for swords and armour. In western Europe, the mounted knight, clad in increasingly complex armour, became a central figure in the culture of chivalry, as well as a highly effective fighting man.

European warfare also repeatedly demonstrated the effectiveness of disciplined foot soldiers – from the Genoese crossbowmen, to the longbowmen of the English kings, to the Swiss with their pikes. The use of gunpowder also crept into warfare during this era – initially as a peripheral novelty, valued more for its surprise effect of flashes and bangs than for its practical impact. In 15th-century Europe, however, improvements in the construction of metal cannon, and in the quality of gunpowder, created the potential for a transformation in siege warfare and fortifications. Large guns had made the tall, stone walls of the medieval castle obsolete by 1500, but it would take considerably longer for the armoured knight to disappear from the battlefield.

KEY DATES



THE BATTLE OF POITIERS (TOURS) – 732



THE BATTLE OF HASTINGS – 1066



MONGOLS AT WAR – c.13TH CENTURY

